

2 Social stratification

Men have long dreamed of an egalitarian society, a society in which all members are equal. In such a society men will no longer be ranked in terms of prestige. No one will experience the satisfaction of occupying a high social status; no one will suffer the indignity of being relegated to a position which commands little respect. No longer will high status evoke deference and admiration or envy and resentment from those in less worthy positions. Wealth will be distributed equally amongst the population. The rich and poor, haves and have-nots will be a thing of the past. Words such as privilege and poverty will either change their meaning or disappear from the vocabulary. In an egalitarian society, the phrase 'power to the people' will become a reality. No longer will some have power over others. Positions of authority and the obedience they command will disappear. Exploitation and oppression will be concepts of history which have no place in the description of contemporary social reality. Men will be equal both in the sight of God and in the eyes of their fellow men.

Clearly the egalitarian society remains a dream. All human societies from the simplest to the most complex have some form of social inequality. In particular, power and prestige are unequally distributed between individuals and social groups. In many societies there are also marked differences in the distribution of wealth. Power refers to the degree to which individuals or groups can impose their will on others, with or without the consent of those others. Prestige relates to the amount of esteem or honour associated with social positions, qualities of individuals and styles of life. Wealth refers to material possessions defined as valuable in particular societies. It may include land, livestock, buildings, money and many other forms of property owned by individuals or social groups. This chapter is concerned with the study of the unequal distribution of power, prestige and wealth in society.

It is important at the outset to make a distinction between social inequality and social stratification. The term social inequality simply refers to the existence of socially created inequalities. Social stratification is a particular form of social inequality. It refers to the presence of social groups which are ranked one above the other, usually in terms of the amount of power, prestige and wealth their members possess. Those who belong to a particular group or stratum will have some awareness of common interests and a common identity. They will share a similar life

style which to some degree will distinguish them from members of other social strata. The Indian caste system provides an example of a social stratification system.

Hindu society in traditional India was divided into five main strata: four varnas or castes, and a fifth group, the outcaste, whose members were known as untouchables. Each caste is subdivided into jatis or sub-castes, which in total number many thousands. Jatis are occupational groups – there are carpenter jatis, goldsmith jatis, potter jatis, and so on. Castes are ranked in terms of ritual purity. The Brahmins or priests, members of the highest caste, personify purity, sanctity and holiness. They are the source of learning, wisdom and truth. Only they can perform the most important religious ceremonies. At the other extreme, untouchables are defined as unclean, base and impure, a status which affects all their social relationships. They must perform unclean and degrading tasks such as the disposal of dead animals. They must be segregated from members of the caste system and live on the outskirts of villages or in their own communities in the middle of paddy fields. Their presence pollutes to the extent that even if the shadow of an untouchable falls across the food of a Brahmin it will render it unclean. In general, the hierarchy of prestige based on notions of ritual purity is mirrored by the hierarchy of power. The Brahmins were custodians of the law, and the legal system which they administered was based largely on their pronouncements. Inequalities of wealth were usually linked to those of prestige and power. In a largely rural economy, the Brahmins tended to be the largest landowners and the control of land was monopolized by members of the two highest castes.

As exemplified by caste, social stratification involves a hierarchy of social groups. Members of a particular stratum have a common identity, like interests and a similar life style. They enjoy or suffer the unequal distribution of rewards in society as members of different social groups. Social stratification, however, is only one form of social inequality. It is possible for social inequality to exist without social strata. For example, some sociologists have argued that it is no longer correct to regard Western industrial society, particularly the USA, as being stratified in terms of a class system. They suggest that social classes have been replaced by a continuous hierarchy of unequal positions. Where there were once classes, whose members had a consciousness of kind, a common way of life and shared interests, there is now an unbroken continuum of occupational statuses which command varying degrees of prestige and economic reward. Thus it is suggested that a hierarchy of social groups has been replaced by a hierarchy of individuals. Although many sociologists use the terms social inequality and social stratification interchangeably, the importance of seeing social stratification as a specific form of social inequality will become apparent as the chapter develops.

Before looking at some of the major issues raised in the study of social

stratification, it is necessary to examine certain aspects of stratification systems. There is a tendency for members of each stratum to develop their own subculture, that is certain norms, attitudes and values which are distinctive to them as a social group. When some members of society experience similar circumstances and problems which are not common to all members, a subculture tends to develop. For example, it has often been suggested that distinctive working-class and middle-class subcultures exist in Western industrial societies. Similar circumstances and problems often produce similar responses. Members of the lowest stratum in stratification systems which provide little opportunity for the improvement of status tend to have a fatalistic attitude towards life. This attitude becomes part of their subculture and is transmitted from generation to generation. It sees circumstances as largely unchangeable; it sees luck and fate rather than individual effort as shaping life and therefore tends to encourage acceptance of the situation. An attitude of fatalism may be seen in typical phrases from traditional low-income Black American subculture such as, 'I've been down so long that down don't bother me', 'I was born under a bad sign' and 'It's an uphill climb to the bottom'. Members of a social group who share similar circumstances and a common subculture will be likely to develop a group identity. They tend to have a consciousness of kind, a feeling of kinship with other group members. They will therefore tend to identify with their particular stratum and regard themselves, for example, as middle or working class.

Strata subcultures tend to be particularly distinctive when there is little opportunity to move from one stratum to another. This movement is known as social mobility. Social mobility can be upward, for example moving from the working to the middle class, or downward. Stratification systems which provide little opportunity for social mobility may be described as 'closed', those with a relatively high rate of social mobility as 'open'. In closed systems an individual's position is largely ascribed. Often it is fixed at birth and there is little he can do to change his status. Caste provides an example of a closed stratification system. An individual automatically belongs to the caste of his parents and, except in rare instances, spends the rest of his life in that status. By comparison, social class, the system of stratification in capitalist industrial society, provides an example of an open system. Some sociologists claim that an individual's class position is largely achieved. It results from his personal qualities and abilities and the use he makes of them rather than ascribed characteristics such as the status of his parents or the colour of his skin. By comparison with the caste, the rate of social mobility in class systems is high.

A person's position in a stratification system may have important effects on many areas of his life. It may enhance or reduce his 'life chances', that is his chances of obtaining those things defined as desirable and avoiding those things defined as undesirable in his society. Referring

to Western society Gerth and Mills state that life chances include, 'Everything from the chance to stay alive during the first year after birth to the chance to view fine arts, the chance to remain healthy and grow tall, and if sick to get well again quickly, the chance to avoid becoming a juvenile delinquent and very crucially, the chance to complete an intermediary or higher educational grade'. A comparison of Blacks and Whites in the USA provides an illustration of the effect of one stratification system on life chances. Blacks and certain other ethnic minority groups form the base of the stratification system. The rate of infant mortality among Blacks is twice that of Whites and the proportion of Black mothers dying during childbirth is four times that for Whites. Compared to Whites, Blacks are less likely to acquire educational qualifications, their marriages are more likely to end in separation or divorce and they are more likely to have a criminal record. Many sociologists would see these differences in life chances as a direct consequence of social stratification.

Social versus natural inequalities

Many stratification systems are accompanied by beliefs which state that social inequalities are biologically based. Such beliefs are often found in systems of racial stratification where, for example, Whites claim biological superiority over Blacks and see this as the basis for their dominance. The question of the relationship between biologically based and socially created inequality has proved extremely difficult to answer. The French philosopher Jean-Jacques Rousseau provided one of the earliest examinations of this question. He refers to biologically based inequality as 'natural or physical, because it is established by nature, and consists in a difference of age, health, bodily strength, and the qualities of the mind or the soul'. By comparison, socially created inequality 'consists of the different privileges which some men enjoy to the prejudice of others, such as that of being more rich, more honoured, more powerful, or even in a position to exact obedience' (quoted in Bottomore, 1965, pp. 15-16). Rousseau believed that biologically based inequalities between men were small and relatively unimportant whereas socially created inequalities provide the major basis for systems of social stratification. Most sociologists would support this view.

However, it could still be argued that biological inequalities, no matter how small, provide the foundation upon which structures of social inequality are built. This position is difficult to defend in the case of certain forms of stratification. In the caste system, an individual's status is fixed by birth. A person belongs to his parents' jati and automatically follows the occupation of the jati into which he was born. Thus no matter what the biologically based aptitudes and capacities of an untouchable, there is no way he can become a Brahmin. Unless it is assumed that superior

genes are permanently located in the Brahmin caste, and there is no evidence that this is the case, then there is probably no relationship between genetically based and socially created inequality in traditional Hindu society. A similar argument can be advanced in connection with the feudal or estate system of medieval Europe. Stratification in the feudal system was based on landholding. The more land an individual controlled, the greater his wealth, power and prestige. The position of the dominant stratum, the feudal nobility, was based on large grants of land from the king. Their status was hereditary, land and titles being passed on from father to son. It is difficult to sustain the argument that feudal lords ultimately owed their position to biological superiority when a son, no matter what his biological make-up, inherited the status of his father.

The most stubborn defence of the biological argument has been provided for systems of racial stratification. In the USA, Black Americans, who make up 12% of the population, have traditionally formed a distinct social stratum at the base of the stratification system. The majority of Blacks occupied the most menial and subservient occupational statuses, being employed as agricultural labourers and as unskilled and semi-skilled manual workers in industry. In the mid 1960s, the average income for Black families was only 54% of the average for White families. Blacks had little political power being scarcely represented in local and national government: in 1962, in the southern states, only six Blacks were elected to public office. This system of racial stratification has often been explained in terms of the supposed genetically based inferiority of Blacks. In particular, it has been argued that Blacks are innately inferior to Whites in terms of intelligence. 'Scientific' support for this view has been provided by intelligence tests which indicate that on average Blacks score fifteen points below Whites.

However, most sociologists would argue that systems of racial stratification have a social rather than a biological basis. They would maintain that systematic discrimination against Blacks, made possible by the power of the dominant stratum, accounts for the system of racial stratification in the USA. Thus Blacks have been excluded from high status occupations because of lack of power rather than the quality of their genes. Support for this view is provided by evidence from the late 1960s and 1970s. During the mid 1960s, in the USA, laws were passed banning racial discrimination in areas such as employment, politics and education. Blacks are now moving out of the lowest stratum in ever increasing numbers. By 1971, seventy Blacks were elected to public office in the southern states. Although the figure is small, it represents a dramatic increase. Black family income is slowly approaching the White average. From 1960 to 1970, the percentage of Blacks employed in professional, managerial and technical occupations rose steadily and in some cases doubled. This evidence suggests that social rather than biological mechanisms were responsible for the traditional status of Blacks in the USA.

The question of the relationship between intelligence and social inequality is particularly difficult to answer. The average intelligence quotient of Blacks in America is still significantly below that of Whites. In addition, Blacks are still disproportionately represented in the lower levels of the stratification system. Since it is generally agreed that intelligence has a genetic component, can it not be argued that social inequality has a biological basis? This question will be examined in detail in the chapter on education. (See pps. 189-93.) However, a few preliminary remarks can be made to refute this view. Firstly, intelligence is based on both genetic and environmental factors; the two are inseparable. Thus an individual's social background will affect his performance in an IQ test. In particular, the deprivations he experiences as a member of a low social stratum will reduce his IQ score. Secondly, many researchers argue that intelligence tests are based on White middle-class knowledge and skills and are therefore biased against Blacks. Thirdly, the tests measure only a small part of the range of mental abilities. Most sociologists would therefore conclude that the social status of Blacks in the USA is the result of a social rather than a biological mechanism.

So far the question of what exactly constitutes biological inequality has not been answered. It can be argued that biological differences become biological inequalities when men define them as such. Thus André Beteille states that, 'Natural inequality is based on differences in quality, and qualities are not just there, so to say, in nature; they are as human beings have defined them, in different societies, in different historical epochs'. Biological factors assume importance in many stratification systems because of the meanings assigned to them by different cultures. For example, old age has very different meanings in different societies. In traditional aborigine societies in Australia it brought high prestige and power since the elders directed the affairs of the tribe. But in Western societies, the elderly are usually pensioned off and old age assumes a very different meaning. Even with a change of name to senior citizen, the status of old age pensioner commands little power or prestige. So-called racial characteristics are evaluated on the basis of similar principles, that is values which are relative to time and place. The physical characteristics of Blacks in America were traditionally defined as undesirable and associated with a range of negative qualities. However, with the rise of Black Power during the late 1960s, this evaluation was slowly changed with slogans such as 'Black is beautiful'. It can therefore be argued that biological differences become biological inequalities only to the extent that they are defined as such. They form a component of some social stratification systems simply because members of those systems select certain characteristics and evaluate them in a particular way. André Beteille argues that the search for a biological basis for social stratification is bound to end in failure since the 'identification as well as the gradation of qualities is a cultural and not a natural process'.

Beliefs which state that systems of social stratification are based on biological inequalities can be seen as rationalizations for those systems. Such beliefs serve to explain the system to its members: they make social inequality appear rational and reasonable. They therefore justify and legitimate the system by appeals to nature. In this way a social contrivance appears to be founded on the natural order of things.

Social stratification – a functionalist perspective

Functionalist theories of stratification must be seen in the context of functionalist theories of society. When functionalists attempt to explain systems of social stratification, they set their explanations in the framework of larger theories which seek to explain the operation of society as a whole. They assume that there are certain basic needs or functional prerequisites which must be met if society is to survive. They therefore look to social stratification to see how far it meets these functional prerequisites. They assume that the parts of society form an integrated whole and thus examine the ways in which the social stratification system is integrated with other parts of society. Functionalists maintain that a certain degree of order and stability are essential for the operation of social systems. They will therefore consider how stratification systems help to maintain order and stability in society. In summary, functionalists are primarily concerned with the function of social stratification, with its contribution to the maintenance and well-being of society.

Talcott Parsons

Like many functionalists, Talcott Parsons believes that order, stability and cooperation in society are based on value consensus, that is a general agreement by members of society concerning what is good and worthwhile. Parsons argues that stratification systems derive from common values. It follows from the existence of values that individuals will be evaluated and therefore placed in some form of rank order. In Parsons's words, 'Stratification, in its valuational aspect, then, is the ranking of units in a social system in accordance with the common value system'. Thus those who perform successfully in terms of society's values will be ranked highly and they will be likely to receive a variety of rewards. At a minimum they will be accorded high prestige since they exemplify and personify common values. For example, if a society places a high value on bravery and generosity, as in the case of the Sioux Indians, those who excel in terms of these qualities will receive a high rank in the stratification system. The Sioux warrior who successfully raids the Crow and Pawnee, the traditional enemies of his tribe, captures horses and distributes them to others, may receive the following rewards. He may be

given a seat on the tribal council, a position of power and prestige. His deeds will be recounted in the warrior societies and the squaws will sing of his exploits. Other warriors will follow him in raids against neighbouring tribes and the success of these expeditions may lead to his appointment as a war chief. In this way excellence in terms of Sioux values is rewarded by power and prestige. Since different societies have different value systems, the ways of attaining a high position will vary from society to society. Parsons argues that American society values individual achievement, efficiency and 'puts primary emphasis on productive activity within the economy'. Thus the successful business executive who has achieved his position through his own initiative, ability and ambition, and runs an efficient and productive business will receive high rewards.

Parsons's argument suggests that stratification is an inevitable part of all human societies. If value consensus is an essential component of all societies, then it follows that some form of stratification will result from the ranking of individuals in terms of common values. It also follows from Parsons's argument that there is a general belief that stratification systems are just, right and proper, since they are basically an expression of shared values. Thus the American business executive is seen to deserve his rewards because members of society place a high value on his skills and achievements. This is not to say there is no conflict between the haves and have-nots, the highly rewarded and those who receive little reward. Parsons recognizes that in Western industrial society, 'There will be certain tendencies to arrogance on the part of some winners and to resentment and to a "sour grapes" attitude on the part of some losers'. However, he believes that this conflict is kept in check by the common value system which justifies the unequal distribution of rewards.

Functionalists tend to see the relationship between social groups in society as one of cooperation and interdependence. Particularly in complex industrial societies, different groups specialize in particular activities. As no one group is self-sufficient it cannot meet the needs of its members. It must, therefore, exchange goods and services with other groups, and so the relationship between social groups is one of reciprocity. This relationship extends to the strata in a stratification system. To present an oversimplified example, it can be argued that many occupational groups within the middle class in Western society plan, organize and coordinate the activities of the working class. Each class needs and cooperates with the other since any large-scale task requires both organization and execution. In societies with a highly specialized division of labour, such as industrial societies, some members will specialize in organization and planning, others will follow their directives. Talcott Parsons argues that this inevitably leads to inequality in terms of power and prestige. Referring to Western society, he states that, 'Organization on an ever increasing scale is a fundamental feature of such a system. Such organization naturally involves centralization and differentiation of

leadership and authority; so that those who take responsibility for coordinating the actions of many others must have a different status in important respects from those who are essentially in the role of carrying out specifications laid down by others'. Thus those with the power to organize and coordinate the activities of others will have a higher social status than those they direct.

As with prestige differentials, Parsons argues that inequalities of power are based on shared values. Power is legitimate authority in that it is generally accepted as just and proper by members of society as a whole. It is accepted as such because those in positions of authority use their power to pursue collective goals which derive from society's central values. Thus the power of the American business executive is seen as legitimate authority because it is used to further productivity, a goal shared by all members of society. This use of power therefore serves the interests of society as a whole.

Parsons sees social stratification as both inevitable and functional for society. It is inevitable because it derives from shared values which are a necessary part of all social systems. It is functional because it serves to integrate various groups in society. Power and prestige differentials are essential for the coordination and integration of a specialized division of labour. Without social inequality, Parsons finds it difficult to see how members of society could effectively cooperate and work together. Finally, inequalities of power and prestige benefit all members of society since they serve to further collective goals which are based on shared values. Parsons has been strongly criticized on all these points. Other sociologists have seen stratification as a divisive rather than an integrating force. They have seen it as an arrangement whereby some gain at the expense of others. They have questioned the view that stratification systems derive ultimately from shared values. These criticisms will be examined in detail in later sections.

Kingsley Davis and Wilbert E. Moore

The most famous functionalist theory of stratification was first presented in 1945, in an article by the American sociologists Davis and Moore entitled, *Some Principles of Stratification*. Davis and Moore begin with the observation that stratification exists in every known human society. They attempt to explain 'in functional terms, the universal necessity which calls forth stratification in any social system'. They argue that all social systems share certain functional prerequisites which must be met if the system is to survive and operate efficiently. One such functional prerequisite is effective role allocation and performance. This means that firstly, all roles must be filled, secondly that they be filled by those best able to perform them, thirdly that the necessary training for them be undertaken and fourthly that the roles be performed conscientiously. Davis and

Moore argue that all societies need some mechanism for insuring effective role allocation and performance. This mechanism is social stratification which they see as a system which attaches unequal rewards and privileges to the different positions in society.

If the people and positions which make up society did not differ in important respects there would be no need for stratification. However, people differ in terms of their innate ability and talent. Positions differ in terms of their importance for the survival and maintenance of society. Certain positions are more 'functionally important' than others. They require special skills for their effective performance and there are a limited number of individuals with the necessary ability to acquire such skills. A major function of stratification is to match the most able people with the functionally most important positions. It does this by attaching high rewards to those positions. The desire for such rewards motivates people to compete for them and in theory the most talented will win through. Such positions usually require long periods of training which involve certain sacrifices such as loss of income. The promise of high rewards is necessary to provide an incentive to encourage people to undergo this training and to compensate them for the sacrifice involved. It is essential for the well-being of society that those who hold the functionally most important positions perform their roles diligently and conscientiously. The high rewards built into these positions provide the necessary inducement and generate the required motivation for such performance. Thus Davis and Moore conclude that social stratification is a 'device by which societies insure that the most important positions are conscientiously filled by the most qualified persons'.

Davis and Moore realise that one difficulty with their theory is to show clearly which positions are functionally most important. The fact that a position is highly rewarded does not necessarily mean it is functionally important. They suggest that the importance of a position can be measured in two ways. Firstly by the 'degree to which a position is functionally unique, there being no other positions that can perform the same function satisfactorily'. Thus it could be argued that a doctor is functionally more important than a nurse since his position carries with it many of the skills necessary to perform a nurse's role but not vice versa. The second measure of importance is the 'degree to which other positions are dependent on the one in question'. Thus it may be argued that managers are more important than routine office staff since the latter are dependent on direction and organization from management.

To summarize, Davis and Moore regard social stratification as a 'functional necessity' for all societies. They see it as a solution to a problem faced by all social systems, that of 'placing and motivating individuals in the social structure'. They offer no other means of solving this problem and imply that social inequality is an inevitable feature of human society. They conclude that differential rewards are functional for society, that

they contribute to the maintenance and well-being of social systems.

Melvin M. Tumin

Davis and Moore's views provoked a long debate. Tumin, their most famous opponent, has produced a comprehensive criticism of their theory. He begins by questioning the adequacy of their measurement of the functional importance of positions. Davis and Moore have tended to assume that the most highly rewarded positions are indeed the most important. However, many occupations which afford little prestige or economic reward can be seen as vital to society. Thus, Tumin argues that 'some labour force of unskilled workmen is as important and as indispensable to the factory as some labour force of engineers'. In fact a number of sociologists have argued that there is no objective way of measuring the functional importance of positions. Whether one considers lawyers and doctors as more important than farm labourers and refuse collectors is simply a matter of opinion.

Tumin argues that Davis and Moore have ignored the influence of power on the unequal distribution of rewards. Thus differences in pay and prestige between occupational groups may be due to differences in their power rather than their functional importance. For example, the difference between the wages of farm labourers and coal miners can be interpreted as a result of the bargaining power of the two groups. This point will be examined in detail in later sections.

Davis and Moore assume that only a limited number of individuals have the talent to acquire the skills necessary for the functionally most important positions. Tumin regards this as a very questionable assumption. Firstly, as the chapter on education will indicate, an effective method of measuring talent and ability has yet to be devised. Secondly, there is no proof that exceptional talents are required for those positions which Davis and Moore consider important. Thirdly, the chapter on education will suggest that the pool of talent in society may be considerably larger than Davis and Moore assume. As a result, unequal rewards may not be necessary to harness it.

Tumin also questions the view that the training required for important positions should be regarded as a sacrifice and therefore in need of compensation. He points to the rewards of being a student – leisure, freedom and the opportunity for self-development. He notes that any loss of earnings can usually be made up during the first ten years of work. Differential rewards during this period may be justified. However, Tumin sees no reason for continuing this compensation for the rest of an individual's working life.

According to Davis and Moore, the major function of unequal rewards is to motivate talented individuals and allocate them to the functionally most important positions. Tumin rejects this view. He argues that social

stratification can, and often does, act as a barrier to the motivation and recruitment of talent. This is readily apparent in closed systems such as caste and racial stratification. Thus the ascribed status of untouchables prevented even the most talented from becoming Brahmins. Until recently, the ascribed status of Blacks in the USA blocked all but a handful from political office and highly rewarded occupations. Thus closed stratification systems operate in exactly the opposite way to Davis and Moore's theory.

Tumin suggests, however, that even relatively open systems of stratification erect barriers to the motivation and recruitment of talent. As the chapter on education will show, there is considerable evidence to indicate that the class system in Western industrial society limits the possibilities of the discovery and utilization of talent. In general, the lower an individual's class position, the more likely he is to leave school at the minimum leaving age and the less likely he is to aspire to and strive for a highly rewarded position. Thus the motivation to succeed is unequally distributed throughout the class system. As a result social class can act as an obstacle to the motivation of talent. In addition, Tumin argues that Davis and Moore have failed to consider the possibility that those who occupy highly rewarded positions will erect barriers to recruitment. Occupational groups often use their power to restrict access to their positions, so creating a high demand for their services and increasing the rewards they receive. Tumin claims that the American Medical Association has been guilty of this practice. By its control of entry into the profession, it has maintained a shortage of doctors and so ensured high rewards for medical services. In this way the self-interested use of power can restrict the recruitment of talented individuals to highly rewarded positions.

Tumin concludes that stratification, by its very nature, can never adequately perform the functions which Davis and Moore assign to it. He argues that those born into the lower strata can never have the same opportunities for realizing their talents as those born into the higher strata. Tumin maintains that, 'It is only when there is a genuinely equal access to recruitment and training for all potentially talented persons that differential rewards can conceivably be justified as functional. And stratification systems are apparently *inherently antagonistic* to the development of such full equality of opportunity'.

Finally, Tumin questions the view that social stratification functions to integrate the social system. He argues that differential rewards can 'encourage hostility, suspicion and distrust among the various segments of a society'. From this viewpoint, stratification is a divisive rather than an integrating force. Stratification can also weaken social integration by giving members of the lower strata a feeling of being excluded from participation in the larger society. This is particularly apparent in systems of racial stratification. For example, the saying 'On the outside looking in', is a typical phrase from traditional Black American subculture. By

tending to exclude certain groups from full participation in society, stratification 'serves to distribute loyalty unequally in the population' and therefore reduces the potential for social solidarity. Tumin concludes that in their enthusiastic search for the positive functions of stratification, the functionalists have tended to ignore or play down its many dysfunctions.

Michael Young

Many of the criticisms of Davis and Moore's views have been based on evidence which indicates that no stratification system operates as their theory argues. Even in the relatively open systems of Western industrial societies, there is considerable evidence to suggest that large numbers of able and talented individuals remain in the lower strata. Research has also indicated that many members of the upper strata owe their position primarily to the fact that they have been born into those strata and have capitalized on the advantages provided by their social background. In a brilliant satire entitled *The Rise of the Meritocracy*, Michael Young imagines a future British society in which talent and social roles would be perfectly matched, in which the most able individuals would fill the functionally most important positions. Social status would be achieved on the basis of merit in a society where all members have an equal opportunity to realize their talents. Following Michael Young's usage of the term, such a system of role allocation has come to be known as a meritocracy.

Despite removing the most obvious criticism of Davis and Moore's theory, Young questions the proposition that a stratification system based on meritocratic principles would be functional for society. He notes the following dysfunctional possibilities. Firstly, members of the lower strata may become totally demoralized. In all previous stratification systems they have been able to divert blame from themselves for their lowly status by providing reasons for their failure. They could claim that they never had the opportunity to be successful whereas those who filled the top jobs owed their position to their relatives, friends and the advantages of birth. However, in a meritocracy, those at the bottom are clearly inferior. As a result they may become demoralized since, as Young states, 'Men who have lost their self-respect are liable to lose their inner vitality'. Since all members of a meritocracy are socialized to compete for the top jobs and instilled with ambition, failure could be particularly frustrating. Young argues that, 'When ambition is crossed with stupidity it may do nothing besides foster frustration'. In a meritocracy, talent and ability are efficiently syphoned out of the lower strata. As a result these groups are in a particularly vulnerable position because they have no able members to represent their interests.

Members of the upper strata in a meritocracy deserve their position;

their privileges are based on merit. In the past they had a degree of self-doubt because many realized that they owed their position to factors other than merit. Since they could recognize 'intelligence, wit and wisdom' in members of the lower strata, they appreciated that their social inferiors were at least their equal in certain respects. As a result they would accord the lower orders some respect and the arrogance which high status tends to encourage would be tempered with a degree of humility. All this may change in a meritocracy. Social inferiors really are inferior, those who occupy the top positions are undoubtedly superior. Young argues that this may result in an upper stratum free from self-doubt and the restraining influence of humility. Its members may rule society with arrogance and haughty self-assurance. They may despise the lower strata whose members may well find such behaviour offensive. This may result in conflict between the ruling minority and the rest of society.

Although Young's picture of a meritocracy is fictional, it indicates many of the possible dysfunctional elements of such a system. It suggests that a society based on meritocratic principles may not be well integrated. It indicates that a stratification system which operates in this way may, on balance, be dysfunctional. Young's ideas are important because they cast serious doubt on liberal views of a just society. As the chapter on education will illustrate, many liberal reforms have aimed to create greater equality of opportunity, to give every member of society an equal chance of becoming unequal. Michael Young's picture of a fully operative meritocracy suggests that the liberal dream of a fair and just society may produce a far from perfect reality.

Eva Rosenfeld

So far, criticism of functionalist theories has been concerned with the view that stratification is functional. This section turns to the functionalists' claim that stratification is inevitable. The chapter began by posing the possibility of an egalitarian society, a society without social inequality. An example of one attempt to translate this idea into reality is provided by the Israeli Kibbutzim system. In Israel about 4% of the population live in some 240 kibbutzim. These communities have an average population of between 200 and 700 and an economic base of agriculture plus some light industry. Many kibbutzim are founded on the Marxist principle of 'from everyone according to ability - to everyone according to need', the guiding ideal being the creation of an egalitarian society. Property such as machinery, buildings and produce is communally owned. Commodities such as clothing, shoes and toiletries are distributed to members according to their need. Services such as cooking, laundry and the education of children are freely available to all. Wages as such and therefore wage differentials do not exist in many kibbutzim.

Stratification in terms of wealth is thus absent. All major decisions are taken by a general assembly in which each adult member of a kibbutz has the right to vote. It would therefore appear that power to the people has become a reality.

Despite these arrangements designed to create an egalitarian society, social inequality exists in the kibbutzim. From her research, Eva Rosenfeld had identified two distinct social strata which are clearly recognized by members. The upper stratum is made up of 'leader-managers', who are elected by members of the kibbutz and are responsible for the day-to-day running of the community. The lower stratum consists of the 'rank and file', the agricultural labourers and machine operatives. Authority and prestige are not equally distributed. The right to organize and direct the activities of others is built into the role of leader-manager. In addition the status itself carries high prestige. Rosenfeld notes that leader-managers are 'respected for their contribution to the communal enterprise as leaders, organizers, managers of farms and shops'. Rosenfeld also identifies an 'unequal distribution of seemingly crucial emotional gratifications'. Managers obtain more satisfaction from their work than the rank and file. In the words of one old-timer, members of the rank and file sometimes ask, 'What the hell am I breaking my neck for? What do I get out of this?' There is evidence of a conflict of interest between the two strata. Managers call for 'ever greater effort and self-sacrifice' whereas the rank and file are often apathetic to such exhortations and concerned with more immediate rises in their living standards. Managers are sometimes accused of not knowing 'what kibbutz life tastes like' while they in turn sometimes accuse the rank and file of insufficient effort and failing to appreciate the long-term goals of the kibbutz.

Rosenfeld's study lends some support to the functionalist claim that social stratification, at least in terms of power and prestige, is inevitable in human society. The position of leader-manager in the kibbutz carries authority and commands high prestige. Those who occupy such positions form a fairly distinct social stratum. Talcott Parsons has argued that any division of labour requires an authority structure to organize and coordinate the various specialized tasks involved. He also maintains that in order to operate effectively, positions of authority must carry higher prestige than positions subject to that authority. Despite the logic of these arguments and the evidence which supports them, they do not prove that social stratification is inevitable. Simply because the egalitarian society has yet to become a reality does not mean it is not possible.

Social stratification – a Marxian perspective

Marxian perspectives provide a radical alternative to functionalist views

of the nature of social stratification. They regard stratification as a divisive rather than an integrative structure. They see it as a mechanism whereby some exploit others rather than a means of furthering collective goals. They focus on social strata rather than social inequality in general. Functionalists such as Parsons and Davis and Moore say little about social stratification in the sense of clearly defined social strata whose members have shared interests. However, this view of social stratification is central to Marxian theory.

Marx's views will first be briefly summarized and then examined in more detail.

In all stratified societies, there are two major social groups: a ruling class and a subject class. The power of the ruling class derives from its ownership and control of the forces of production. The ruling class exploits and oppresses the subject class. As a result, there is a basic conflict of interest between the two classes. The various institutions of society such as the legal and political systems are instruments of ruling class domination and serve to further its interests. Only when the forces of production are communally owned will classes disappear, thereby bringing an end to the exploitation and oppression of some by others.

From a Marxian perspective, systems of stratification derive from the relationships of social groups to the forces of production. Marx used the term class to refer to the main strata in all stratification systems, though most modern sociologists would reserve the term for strata in capitalist society. From a Marxian view, a class is a social group whose members share the same relationship to the forces of production. Thus during the feudal epoch, there are two main classes distinguished by their relationship to land, the major force of production. They are the feudal nobility who own the land and the landless serfs who work the land. Similarly, in the capitalist era, there are two main classes, the bourgeoisie or capitalist class which owns the forces of production and the proletariat or working class whose members own only their labour which they hire to the bourgeoisie in return for wages.

Marx believed that Western society had developed through four main epochs: primitive communism, ancient society, feudal society and capitalist society. Primitive communism is represented by the societies of pre-history and provides the only example of a classless society. From then on, all societies are divided into two major classes: masters and slaves in ancient society, lords and serfs in feudal society and capitalists and wage labourers in capitalist society. During each historical epoch, the labour power required for production was supplied by the subject class, that is by slaves, serfs and wage labourers respectively. The subject class is made up of the majority of the population whereas the ruling or dominant class forms a minority. The relationship between the two major classes will be discussed shortly.

Classes did not exist during the era of primitive communism when

societies were based on a socialist mode of production. In a hunting and gathering band, the earliest form of human society, the land and its products were communally owned. The men hunted and the woman gathered plant food, and the produce was shared by members of the band. Classes did not exist since all members of society shared the same relationship to the forces of production. Every member was both producer and owner, all provided labour power and shared the products of their labour. Hunting and gathering is a subsistence economy which means that production only meets basic survival needs. Classes emerge when the productive capacity of society expands beyond the level required for subsistence. This occurs when agriculture becomes the dominant mode of production. In an agricultural economy, only a section of society is needed to produce the food requirements of the whole society. Thus many individuals are freed from food production and are able to specialize in other tasks. The rudimentary division of labour of the hunting and gathering band was replaced by an increasingly more complex and specialized division. For example, in the early agricultural villages, some individuals became full-time producers of pottery, clothing and agricultural implements. As agriculture developed, surplus wealth, that is goods above the basic subsistence needs of the community, was produced. This led to an exchange of goods and trading developed rapidly both within and between communities. This was accompanied by the development of a system of private property. Goods were increasingly seen as commodities or articles of trade to which the individual rather than the community had right of ownership. Private property and the accumulation of surplus wealth form the basis for the development of class societies. In particular, they provide the preconditions for the emergence of a class of producers and a class of non-producers. Some are able to acquire the forces of production and others are therefore obliged to work for them. The result is a class of non-producers which owns the forces of production and a class of producers which owns only its labour power.

From a Marxian perspective, the relationship between the major social classes is one of mutual dependence and conflict. Thus in capitalist society, the bourgeoisie and proletariat are dependent upon each other. The wage labourer must sell his labour power in order to survive since he does not own a part of the forces of production and lacks the means to produce goods independently. He is therefore dependent for his livelihood on the capitalists and the wages they offer. The capitalists, as non-producers, are dependent on the labour power of wage labourers. Without it, there would be no production. However, the mutual dependency of the two classes is not a relationship of equal or symmetrical reciprocity. Instead, it is a relationship of exploiter and exploited, oppressor and oppressed. In particular, the ruling class gains at the expense of the subject class and there is therefore a conflict of interest

between them. This may be illustrated by Marx's view of the nature of ownership and production in capitalist society.

The basic characteristics of a capitalist economy may be summarized as follows. Capital may be defined as money used to finance the production of commodities for private gain. In a capitalist economy goods, and the labour power, raw materials and machinery used to produce them, are given a monetary value. The capitalist invests his capital in the production of goods. Capital is accumulated by selling those goods at a value greater than their cost of production. In Raymond Aron's words, 'The essence of capitalist exchange is to proceed from money to money by way of commodity and end up with more money than one had at the outset'. Capitalism therefore involves the investment of capital in the production of commodities with the aim of maximizing profit. Capital is privately owned by a minority, the capitalist class. However, in Marx's view, it is gained from the exploitation of the mass of the population, the working class. Marx argued that capital, as such, produces nothing. Only labour produces wealth. Yet the wages paid to the workers for their labour are well below the value of the goods they produce. The difference between the value of wages and commodities is known as 'surplus value'. This surplus value is appropriated in the form of profit by the capitalists. Since they are non-producers, the bourgeoisie are therefore exploiting the proletariat, the real producers of wealth. Marx maintained that in all class societies, the ruling class exploits and oppresses the subject class.

From a Marxian perspective political power derives from economic power. The power of the ruling class therefore stems from its ownership and control of the forces of production. Since the superstructure of society – the major institutions, values and belief systems – is seen to be largely shaped by the economic infrastructure, the relations of production will be reproduced in the superstructure. Thus the dominance of the ruling class in the relations of production will be reflected in the superstructure. In particular, the political and legal systems will reflect ruling class interests since, in Marx's words, 'The existing relations of production between individuals must necessarily express themselves also as political and legal relations'. For example, the various ownership rights of the capitalist class will be enshrined in and protected by the laws of the land. Thus the various parts of the superstructure can be seen as instruments of ruling class domination and as mechanisms for the oppression of the subject class. In the same way, the position of the dominant class is supported by beliefs and values which are systematically generated by the infrastructure. As noted in the previous chapter, Marx refers to the dominant concepts of class societies as ruling class ideology since they justify and legitimate ruling class domination and project a distorted picture of reality. For example, the emphasis on freedom in capitalist society, illustrated by phrases such as 'the free market', 'free democratic societies' and 'the free world', is an illusion which disguises the wage

slavery of the proletariat. Ruling class ideology produces 'false class consciousness', a false picture of the nature of the relationship between social classes. Members of both classes tend to accept the status quo as normal and natural and are largely unaware of the true nature of exploitation and oppression. In this way the conflict of interest between the classes is disguised and a degree of social stability produced but the basic contradictions and conflicts of class societies remain unresolved.

Class and social change

Marx believed that the class struggle was the driving force of social change. He states that, 'The history of all societies up to the present is the history of the class struggle'. A new historical epoch is created by the development of superior forces of production by a new social group. These developments take place within the framework of the previous era. For example, the merchants and industrialists who spearheaded the rise of capitalism emerged during the feudal era. They accumulated capital, laid the foundations for industrial manufacture, factory production and the system of wage labour, all of which were essential components of capitalism. The superiority of the capitalist mode of production led to a rapid transformation of the structure of society. The capitalist class became dominant, and although the feudal aristocracy maintained aspects of its power well into the nineteenth century, it was fighting a losing battle.

The class struggles of history have been between minorities. For example, capitalism developed from the struggle between the feudal aristocracy and the emerging capitalist class, both groups in numerical terms forming a minority of the population. Major changes in history have involved the replacement of one form of private property by another and of one type of production technique by another. For example, capitalism involved the replacement of privately owned land and an agricultural economy by privately owned capital and an industrial economy. Marx believed that the class struggle which would transform capitalist society would involve none of these processes. The protagonists would be the bourgeoisie and the proletariat, a minority versus a majority. Private property would be replaced by communally owned property. Industrial manufacture would remain as the basic technique of production in the society which would replace capitalism.

Marx believed that the basic contradictions contained in a capitalist economic system would lead to its eventual destruction. The proletariat would overthrow the bourgeoisie and seize the forces of production, the source of power. Property would be communally owned and, since all members of society would now share the same relationship to the forces of production, a classless society would result. Since history is the history of the class struggle, history would now end. The communist society which replaces capitalism will contain no contradictions, no conflicts of

interest, and will therefore be unchanging. However, before the dawning of this utopia, certain changes must occur.

Marx distinguished between a 'class in itself' and a 'class for itself'. A class in itself is simply a social group whose members share the same relationship to the forces of production. Marx argues that a social group only fully becomes a class when it becomes a class for itself. At this stage its members have class consciousness and class solidarity. Class consciousness means that false class consciousness has been replaced by a full awareness of the true situation, by a realization of the nature of exploitation. Members of a class develop a common identity, recognize their shared interests and unite, so producing class solidarity. The final stage of class consciousness and class solidarity is reached when members realize that only by collective action can they overthrow the ruling class and when they take positive steps to do so.

Marx believed that the following aspects of capitalist society would eventually lead to the proletariat developing into a class for itself. Firstly capitalist society is by its very nature unstable. It is based on contradictions and antagonisms which can only be resolved by its transformation. In particular, the conflict of interest between the bourgeoisie and the proletariat cannot be resolved within the framework of a capitalist economy. The basic conflict of interest involves the exploitation of workers by the capitalists. Marx believed that this contradiction would be highlighted by a second, the contradiction between social production and individual ownership. As capitalism developed, the workforce was increasingly concentrated in large factories where production was a social enterprise. Social production juxtaposed with individual ownership illuminates the exploitation of the proletariat. Social production also makes it easier for workers to organize themselves against the capitalists. It facilitates communication and encourages a recognition of common circumstances and interests.

Apart from the basic contradictions of capitalist society, Marx believed that certain factors in the natural development of a capitalist economy will hasten its downfall. These factors will result in the polarization of the two main classes. Firstly the increasing use of machinery will result in a homogeneous working class. Since 'machinery obliterates the differences in labour' members of the proletariat will become increasingly similar. The differences between skilled, semi-skilled and unskilled workers will tend to disappear as machines remove the skill required in the production of commodities. Secondly, the difference in wealth between the bourgeoisie and the proletariat will increase as the accumulation of capital proceeds. Even though the real wages and living standards of the proletariat may rise, its members will become poorer in relation to the bourgeoisie. This process is known as pauperization. Thirdly, the competitive nature of capitalism means that only the largest and most wealthy companies will survive and prosper. Competition will depress the

intermediate strata, those groups lying between the two main classes, into the proletariat. Thus the 'petty bourgeoisie', the owners of small businesses, will 'sink into the proletariat'. At the same time the surviving companies will grow larger and capital will be concentrated into fewer hands. These three processes – the obliteration of the differences in labour, the pauperization of the working class and the depression of the intermediate strata into the proletariat – will result in the polarization of the two major classes. Marx believed he could observe the process of polarization in nineteenth-century Britain when he wrote, 'Society as a whole is more and more splitting into two great hostile camps . . . bourgeoisie and proletariat'. Now the battle lines were clearly drawn, Marx hoped that the proletarian revolution would shortly follow and the communist utopia of his dreams would finally become a reality.

Marx's work on class has been examined in detail for the following reasons. Firstly, many sociologists claim that his theory still provides the best explanation of the nature of class in capitalist society. Secondly much of the research on class has been inspired by ideas and questions raised by Marx. Thirdly, many of the concepts of class analysis introduced by Marx have proved useful to Marxists and non-Marxists alike. And, as T. B. Bottomore writing in 1965 notes, 'For the past eighty years Marx's theory has been the object of unrelenting criticism and tenacious defence'. This observation remains true today.

Social stratification – a Weberian perspective

The work of the German sociologist Max Weber (1864–1920) represents one of the most important developments in stratification theory since Marx. The similarities and differences of their approaches will become apparent as Weber's ideas are examined.

Like Marx, Weber sees class in economic terms. He argues that classes develop in market economies in which individuals compete for economic gain. He defines a class as a group of individuals who share a similar position in a market economy and by virtue of that fact receive similar economic rewards. Thus in Weber's terminology, a person's 'class situation' is basically his 'market situation'. Those who share a similar class situation also share similar life chances. Their economic position will directly affect their chances of obtaining those things defined as desirable in their society, for example access to higher education and good quality housing.

Like Marx, Weber argues that the major class division is between those who own the forces of production and those who do not. Thus those who have substantial property holdings will receive the highest economic rewards and enjoy superior life chances. However, Weber sees important differences in the market situation of the propertyless groups in society. In particular the various skills and services offered by different

occupations have differing market values. For example, in capitalist society, managers, administrators and professionals receive relatively high salaries because of the demand for their services. Weber distinguished the following class groupings in capitalist society.

- 1 The propertied upper class
- 2 The propertyless white-collar workers
- 3 The petty bourgeoisie
- 4 The manual working class

In his analysis of class, Weber has parted company with Marx on a number of important issues. Firstly, factors other than the ownership or non-ownership of property are significant in the formation of classes. In particular, the market value of the skills of the propertyless varies and the resulting differences in economic return are sufficient to produce different social classes. Secondly, Weber sees no evidence to support the idea of the polarization of classes. Although he sees some decline in the numbers of the petty bourgeoisie, the small property owners, due to competition from large companies, he argues that they enter white-collar or skilled manual trades rather than being depressed into the ranks of unskilled manual workers. More importantly, Weber argues that the white-collar 'middle class' expands rather than contracts as capitalism develops. He maintains that capitalist enterprises and the modern nation state require a 'rational' bureaucratic administration which involves large numbers of administrators and clerical staff. (Weber's views on bureaucratic administration are outlined in Chapter 7, pp. 279–86.) Thus Weber sees a diversification of classes and an expansion of the white-collar middle class rather than a polarization. Thirdly, Weber rejects the view, held by some Marxists, of the inevitability of the proletarian revolution. He sees no reason why those sharing a similar class situation should necessarily develop a common identity, recognize shared interests and take collective action to further those interests. For example, Weber suggests that the individual manual worker who is dissatisfied with his class situation may respond in a variety of ways. He may grumble, work to rule, sabotage industrial machinery, take strike action or attempt to organize other members of his class in an effort to overthrow capitalism. Weber admits that a common market situation may provide a basis for collective class action but he sees this only as a possibility. Finally Weber rejects the Marxian view that political power necessarily derives from economic power. He argues that class forms only one possible basis for power and that the distribution of power in society is not necessarily linked to the distribution of class inequalities.

While class forms one possible basis for group formation, collective action and the acquisition of political power, Weber argues that there are other bases for these activities. In particular, groups form because their members share a similar 'status situation'. Whereas class refers to the unequal distribution of economic rewards, status refers to the unequal

distribution of 'social honour'. Occupations, ethnic and religious groups and most importantly styles of life are accorded differing degrees of prestige or esteem by members of society. A status group is made up of individuals who are awarded a similar amount of social honour and therefore share the same status situation. Unlike classes, members of status groups are almost always aware of their common status situation. They share a similar life style, identify with and feel they belong to their status group and often place restrictions on the ways in which outsiders may interact with them. Weber argues that status groups reach their most developed form in the caste system of traditional Hindu society in India. Castes and sub-castes are formed and distinguished largely in terms of social honour. Life styles are sharply differentiated and accorded varying degrees of prestige. Barriers are set up to social intercourse between status groups, such as the ban on intercaste marriage. Weber sees status distinctions as the basis of group formation in caste societies.

In many societies class and status situations are closely linked. Weber notes that, 'Property as such is not always recognized as a status qualification, but in the long run it is, and with extraordinary regularity'. However, those who share the same class situation will not necessarily belong to the same status group. For example the *nouveaux riches* (the newly rich) are sometimes excluded from the status groups of the privileged because their tastes, manners and dress are defined as vulgar. Status groups may create divisions within classes. In a study of Banbury, conducted in the 1950s, Margaret Stacey found that members of the manual working class distinguished three status groups within that class: the 'respectable working class', the 'ordinary working class' and the 'rough working class'. Economic factors influenced the formation of these groups, for example the 'roughs' were often in the lowest income bracket, but they did not determine status since the income of many 'roughs' was similar to that of members of other status groups. Status groups can also cut across class divisions. In the USA, Blacks, no matter what their class situation belong to the same status group. This can form the basis for collective political action. For example in the 1960s and 1970s many middle and working-class Blacks united in various organizations under the banner of the Black Power movement.

Weber's observations on status groups are important since they suggest that in certain situations status rather than class provides the basis for the formation of social groups whose members perceive common interests and a group identity. In addition, the presence of different status groups within a single class and of status groups which cut across class divisions can weaken class solidarity and reduce the potential for class consciousness. These points are illustrated by Weber's analysis of 'parties'.

Weber defines 'parties' as groups which are specifically concerned with influencing policies and making decisions in the interests of their

membership. In Weber's words parties are concerned with 'the acquisition of social "power"'. Parties include a variety of associations from the mass political parties of Western democracies to the whole range of pressure or interest groups which include professional associations, trade unions, the Automobile Association and the RSPCA. Parties often represent the interests of classes or status groups, but not necessarily. In Weber's words, 'Parties may represent interests determined through "class situation" or "status situation"'. In most cases they are partly class parties and partly status parties, but sometimes they are neither'. The combination of class and status interests can be seen in the various Black Power organizations in the USA. They represent a status group but they also represent class interests. The majority of Blacks are working-class and many Black organizations are directly concerned with improving their class situation. Weber's view of parties suggests that the relationship between political groups and class and status groups is far from clear cut. Just as status groups can both divide classes and cut across class boundaries, so parties can divide and cut across both classes and status groups.

Weber's analysis of classes, status groups and parties suggests that no single theory can pinpoint and explain their relationship. The interplay of class, status and party in the formation of social groups is complex and variable and must be examined in particular societies during particular time periods. Marx attempted to reduce all forms of inequality to social class and argued that classes formed the only significant social groups in society. Weber argues that the evidence provides a more complex and diversified picture of social stratification.

Class in capitalist society

The two previous sections have examined Marxian and Weberian views of social stratification in general and class in capitalist society in particular. This section is concerned with more recent views of class in capitalist society. It attempts to answer the following questions. What is the class structure of capitalist society? How has it changed? What factors have shaped the class structure? Are classes important social groups in capitalist society?

Like Marx and Weber, most modern sociologists use economic factors as the basic criteria for differentiating social classes. Thus the British sociologist Anthony Giddens identifies three major classes in advanced capitalist society. They are an upper class based on the 'ownership of property in the means of production', a middle class based on the 'possession of educational or technical qualifications' and a lower or working class based on the 'possession of manual labour-power'. These classes are distinguished by their differing relationship to the forces of production